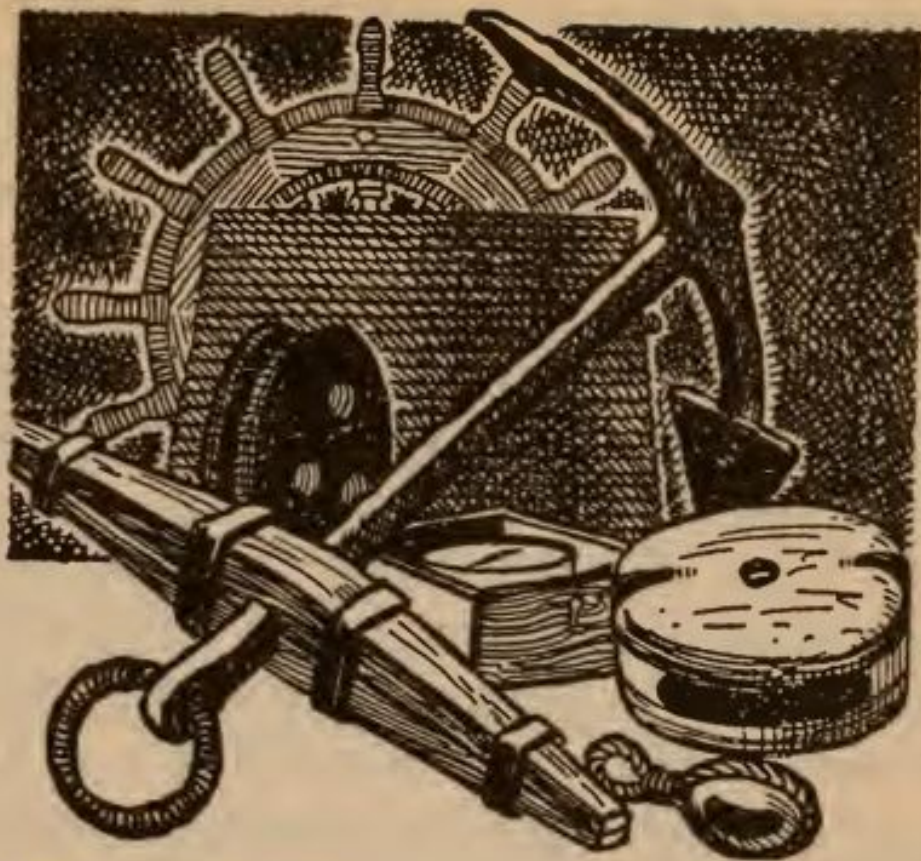


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 6



CHAPTER 6



"SAIL BY ASH BREEZE!"

When Nat had been studying bookkeeping for two weeks, Michael Walsh said, "You're coming along fine, Nat." He smiled. "It isn't going to take you any three months to be ready for Ropes and Hodges! Two months — and you'll be a bookkeeper!"

"Thank you, Mr. Walsh." Heartsick, Nat said good night and started home. Only six more weeks until he'd leave home. Only six more weeks, and then for nine years he could never leave the chandlery or Mr. Hodges' house without permission.

Lizza came to meet him. "Look, Nat!" she whispered. She showed him an advertisement she had found in a *Salem Gazette*:

SIXTY DOLLARS REWARD

Ran away from the subscriber on Monday night the 4th, two indented apprentices . . .

Whoever will take up either or both of said runaways, and return them to the subscriber or secure them in any way shall have a reward of 30 dollars for each.

All persons are forbid harboring or trusting said runaways . . .

“See, Nat?” she whispered. “Being indentured is just like being in jail. If you run away, someone will c-c-capture you and bring you b-b-back.”

Nat's mouth felt dry, but he managed to smile. "But I'm not going to run away, Lizza. What would I want to run away for? I'm going to learn a trade. Come on, we'd better hurry. I have a lot of studying to do after supper."

After they had eaten, Nat spread his work on the table. William and Sammy brought their slates and sat by him, one on each side. Mary worked at her spinning wheel; Lizza knitted a sock. Little Lois bit her tongue and studied her *New England Primer*.

Nat looked around him. His home. His family. In just a little while . . . He tried to swallow the lump in his throat.

William said, "I want a problem, Nat. A big one."

Nat took his slate. "Sure, William. You want one, too, Sammy?" He put problems on both their slates.

For a while there was no sound in the room but the click of Lizza's knitting needles, the hum of Mary's spinning wheel, the squeak of the slate pencils, and the drowsy song Lois was making out of a verse in her *New England Primer*:

*The Moon gives light
In time of night.*

She sang it over and over, to a tune of her own.

Only six more weeks at home. For a moment the work in front of Nat blurred. He blinked, swallowed hard, and began working again. Maybe Mr. Walsh would change his mind. Maybe after two months he'd say, "I think you'd better have another month, Nat." Maybe . . .

But on Friday at the end of Nat's two months, Mr. Hodges came to Michael Walsh's school. Mr. Hodges was a tall, sandy-haired young man, with a long face that looked stern until he smiled. He smiled now at Nat.

"Well, Mr. Walsh, how's Nat getting along? Had he better have another month of training? After all, a lad of twelve — "

Mr. Walsh beamed. "No, indeed! He's amazing! No reason at all to keep him here another month."

Nat's heart sank.

Mr. Hodges said, "Fine. Then, Nat, suppose you come along with me. We'll get you settled in your new home, and then you can begin to get acquainted at the chandlery."

Nat gulped. He said good-by to Mr. Walsh and followed Mr. Hodges out the door.

Presently Mr. Hodges stopped in front of a big, square house. "Here we are." He led the way inside, and up the stairs to the garret. He opened a door. "This will be your room, Nat."

Through a blur of tears Nat saw a narrow bed with a patchwork quilt, a washstand with a bowl and pitcher, a small table, and a chair.

"I think you'll like it," Mr. Hodges said. "You'll have a good view of the harbor."

Nat went to the window and stared hard at the ships until the blurred outlines cleared and he could see masts and rigging.

Mr. Hodges checked the wardrobe and the chest of drawers. "Everything is cleared out and ready for your clothes."

"I have them on," Nat said. "Most of them."

For a moment, Mr. Hodges looked stern; then he smiled. "You'll be getting more clothes, Nat. You see, we have a bargain with you. You keep books for us; we furnish you board, room, and clothes, and teach you the 'trade, art, or mystery' of ship chandlery." He chuckled.

“Sometimes I’m not sure which it is — a trade, an art, or a mystery. Do you think this room will — you’ll be happy here?”

Nat turned quickly to the window and stared hard at the ships again. Presently he said, “Yes, sir, this will be fine.”

“Then suppose we go down to the chandlery and look around.”

When they reached the long wooden building on Neptune Street, a lanky, unshaven man lounged against the door. He said, “Morning, Mr. Hodges. Mr. Ropes had to go on an errand. He asked me to keep an eye on things till you got back.”

Mr. Hodges said, "This is Ben Meeker, Nat. Ben, this is Nat Bowditch, our new apprentice. Suppose you take one of our catalogues, and show Nat where everything is." He pulled two copies of a little flat notebook, about two by five inches, from his pocket, and gave one to Nat and one to Ben.

On the cover Nat read, "Catalogue of Ropes and Hodges — Ship Chandlers." He opened the notebook. The pages were blank, excepting for a single column of words down the middle. Everything seemed to be listed there — from hardtack to copper nails — from sextants to coffeepots.

Mr. Hodges said, "Plenty of blank space, isn't there? That's so a man can mark his order right in the catalogue — so many barrels of this — so many pounds of that. It saves him the bother of writing out his order." He chuckled. "And it saves us the bother of trying to read his writing. All right, Ben, show Nat around."

Ben yawned, stretched, and led the way through the shop to where huge coils of rope were stacked. He leaned against a barrel. "Nat Bowditch, eh? I've heard of you. Master Watson's brightest student you were." He shook his head dolefully. "And now you're becalmed. Just like I was at your age. Wouldn't think to look at me I was bright as a dollar once, would you? But I was. Wanted to make something of myself. But I didn't have a chance.

Taken out of school, I was. Just like you. When I look at you, I can see myself as I was thirty — forty years ago. Becalmed, I was. Just like you.”

Behind Nat a deep voice rumbled, “Avast there, Ben Meeker! Stow that gab about being becalmed!”

Nat looked around and saw keen blue eyes in a square ruddy face, under a shock of white hair.

Ben edged back. “I didn’t say anything but the gospel truth, Sam Smith. This lad ought to be heading for college. But he’s stuck fast in this chandlery for nine years. If he ain’t becalmed — ”

Sam said, "Bah! Only a weakling gives up when he's becalmed! A strong man sails by ash breeze!"

"A strong man, maybe, but what about a puny little —"

Sam gestured with his thumb over his shoulder. "Get out of here, and stay away from this boy. If I see you in here again, I'll give you a taste of a belaying pin!"

Ben scuttled out the door.

Sam put out his hand. "Nat Bowditch, aren't you? I know your father. He sailed under me more than once — before he had his own sloop."

Nat asked, "How do you 'sail by ash breeze'?"

Sam grinned. "When a ship is becalmed — the wind died down — she can't move — sometimes the sailors break out their oars. They'll row a boat ahead of the ship and tow her. Or they'll carry out anchors and heave them over, and the crew will lean on the capstan bars and drag the ship up to where the anchors are heaved over. Oars are made of ash — white ash. So — when you get ahead by your own get-up-and-get — that's when you sail by ash breeze'."

Nat straightened. "I like the sound of that."

"Of course you do." Sam nodded. "You're from a long line of seafaring men!" He lifted his voice to a bellow. "Mr. Hodges! I sent Ben packing! I'll show this lad around and it won't cost you a cent!"

Mr. Hodges called, "I can't ask you to do that, Sam."

"Who's asking me? I'm just doing it!" Sam grinned at Nat. "When an old fellow like me swallows the anchor, he's got to have something to do with his time!"

Mr. Hodges joined them. He gave a large, flat black notebook to Nat. "Would you like to write down everything Sam tells you?"

"Yes, sir! May I use the whole notebook?"

Mr. Hodges chuckled. "That and another one or two. When Sam starts talking, you'll fill a notebook in no time at all!"

Sam chuckled, too. "Come along, Nat. We'll start at the stern and work forward along the starboard bulkhead."

"Nat, do you know what he's talking about?" Mr. Hodges asked.

Nat squared his shoulders. "Yes, sir. The stern is the back and the starboard is the right and a bulkhead is a wall. We're starting at the back and working to the front along the right wall."

Sam clapped his hand on Nat's shoulder. "Make a sailor of him yet, if he ever grows to any size, won't we?" He picked up a flat piece of wood, shaped like a fourth of a pie. "First, Nat, I'll tell you about the log."

Nat studied the pie-shaped piece of wood. "That doesn't look much like a log to me."

"I'll tell you how it got its name. When a captain's at sea, he needs to know how far he has sailed in a day. To figure that out, he has to know how fast he is sailing and how long he has sailed that fast."

"That's arithmetic, isn't it? I like that!"

Sam nodded. "Nearly everything about navigation is arithmetic. Now, here's the way a sailor tells how fast he's going with a log. A long time ago, the Dutch sailors used to figure how fast they were going by throwing a piece of wood — they called it a log — overboard. One man stood forward in the bow of the ship and threw the log into the water. Another man stood aft, in the stern of the ship, and kept track of how many seconds it took until the stern of the ship passed the log.

“They knew how long the ship was. So when they knew how many seconds it took for the ship to go that many feet, they could figure out how many knots it was making. That was the way they measured their speed. They said they *logged* their speed because they figured it with a log. And that’s why we call this pie-shaped piece of wood a *log*; because we use it to log the speed of the ship — you see?

“Now, here’s the way we use this chip log. You see, it’s weighted on the curved side, to make it stand on edge in the water. We heave it over the taffrail, so it trails along behind the ship. We have it tied to a reel of log line. As the ship moves forward, the log stands still in the water, and the line unwinds from the reel. Every so often there’s a marker on the line. We call it a knot. As the reel unwinds, and the line goes over the taffrail of the ship, we begin to check the time when a special marker knot goes over.”

Sam picked up a little glass, shaped like an hour glass, only much smaller. “We check the time with one of these little log glasses. This one is a twenty-eight-second glass. When the sand runs out, the sailor stops the log line. He counts how many knots have run out. That tells him how many knots his ship is going.”

Nat squared his shoulders. "So now I know what it means to keep a log."

Sam bellowed, "No! That isn't keeping a log! Keeping a log is keeping the record of what happens on the voyage."

Nat said, "Then why don't they call it keeping the record?"

"Because one of the most important things in the record is the speed they have logged; so they call the whole record of what happens *the log*."

Nat grinned. "I'm glad you're explaining things to me instead of Ben Meeker."

Sam said, "Ben won't be around here very soon again!"

Weeks passed. Nat had almost forgotten about Ben Meeker when he drifted into the chandlery again one day. Nat was busy at his desk behind the counter, writing things in his notebook.

Ben said, "What's that?"

"That," Nat told him, "is what I'm sailing by! That's an ash breeze!"

Ben shrugged. "I suppose you'll work that way at first. But nine years is a long time. You'll get mighty tired of sailing by ash breeze."



Ropes and Hodges Ship Chandlery

